

When Sex Enters the Group

By Myra Walden

The environment at the extended residential training was deeply healing and nurturing. People from many countries around the world had gathered to learn how to relate to themselves with greater compassion and to one another with increased respect, mutuality, and care. The retreat center was nestled among majestic trees, quietly sheltered by a nearby mountain. Within the group, people related to one another with openness and vulnerability. They listened deeply, and they cared. In such a setting, my defenses began to soften and fall away, and my heart opened wide. I felt safe.

After a few days, I noticed a flirtatious relationship beginning to emerge between a man and a woman, whom I will call Evangeline and David. One morning, after the inspirational practice with which we began each day, we divided into small groups. We sat in a circle, with Evangeline and David seated across from each other and me beside David. At one point, they exchanged a comment across the circle and laughed. Later, during the session, Evangeline looked at David, opened her legs, lifted her skirt high enough to reveal her legs and underwear, then pulled it down again and laughed. Something that may have felt playful and lighthearted to them was unsettling for me. At that moment, the sanctuary I had found in the group was disturbed.

Sexual attraction can arise naturally in settings where people speak vulnerably, listen empathically, and connect deeply. When people encounter one another with such openness and intimacy, it is understandable that emotional closeness may awaken a desire for physical union. Yet the expression of that desire within a shared learning and healing environment, be it in person or remote, can have a profound impact, not only for the individuals involved, but also for the wider group and the delicate field of trust that holds it together.

For several years, I have offered the [Empowerment Therapy](http://www.empowermenttherapy.net) program online through three weekly groups. In each session, participants share personal challenges and receive empathy and care. Over time, this practice creates a cohesive and close-knit community, one in which members come to know one another deeply, form meaningful bonds, and develop a strong sense of connection and belonging. At times, sexually-charged interactions emerge within these relationships.

What follows is an overview of what I have observed over the years in groups when sexual attraction becomes explicit, along with feedback shared by group members.

- A. **The facilitator:** Aware of the potential impact on the group members and the group, I lose self-connection: I become anxious, it's difficult to focus on the subject, and my interactions are laden with tension.
- B. **The group members:** Group members have reported that their focus during the session becomes internal; they have difficulty concentrating. Once, a man said to me privately *"When this happens, I expect the group facilitator to address it."*
- C. **The group:** Members may talk about the situation outside the sessions. They might form alliances thus diminishing group cohesiveness.

I would like to examine this dynamic using Marshall Rosenberg's Nonviolent Communication OFNR (Observation, Feelings, Needs and Request) framework.

Observations

When Person A is attracted to Person B and acts on it, some changes typically take place.

- **Presentation:** Different personal appearance and attire.
- **Posture and perspective:** Different way of sitting and positioning the camera.
- **Interactions:** Person A talks to Person B more frequently; gazes at the camera in a prolonged manner when Person B speaks; validates Person B's contributions more often.

When the interest is mutual, I may notice the following.

- The two group members hold more frequent, direct conversations; they joke and validate each other more often.
- They gaze at the camera when the other person speaks.
- They message each other on the chat.

Group indicators:

- Longer, more frequent silences.
- Reduced participation.

Feelings

Sexually-charged interactions can stimulate the following feelings among group members.

- Tension
- Discomfort
- Distress (particularly for members with a history of sexual abuse)

Needs

- **Needs usually met for the people involved:** connection, appreciation, closeness, and fun.
- **Needs usually not met for the other group members:** safety, presence (ability to remain focused), and community — the sense of oneness is impacted.

Request

When addressing the situation, I follow these steps.

1. I ask to meet individually with the person(s) involved.
2. Seeking to connect first, I follow these steps:
 - a. Share one or two observations.
 - b. Acknowledge the person's need for self-expression, autonomy, and freedom.
 - c. Express my need for cooperation to help create an environment conducive to learning.
 - d. Ask what the person heard and how they feel about it.
 - e. Respond with empathy.
 - f. Ask if there is anything else they want to say.
 - g. When they have nothing else to say and I experience connection, I move to the last step.
3. We discuss a solution together.

A Potential Outcome

Over the years, men often have responded to these conversations with relative calm and even a sense of lightness. For some women, however, the conversations have been more challenging, and a couple of them chose to leave the program. I was told that one woman expressed that she was not willing to be controlled. As I reflect on this, I understand her need to protect her autonomy, particularly given the long history of pain women have experienced regarding their sexual sovereignty. Her response was understandable, but her departure was sad for me. I wish we could have found a way for her to experience respect for her autonomy and for me to receive the cooperation I needed to co-create a conducive learning environment.

Myra Walden has an MA in clinical psychology and has practiced psychotherapy for over 30 years. She is a certified trainer with the Center for Nonviolent Communication and a co-founder of the Empowerment Therapy Institute. She wrote the book [Empowerment Therapy](#).

At the Empowerment Therapy Institute (ETI), we train therapists, coaches and helping professionals on how to develop relationships of trust with clients; implement innovative processes that promote healing, liberation and empowerment; and help clients build more satisfying relationships and more fulfilling lives.

Our fees are comparatively low because we want to train many people who can bring the model to those without access to traditional support services. Please [visit our website](#) for information about our program, or for a referral to an Empowerment practitioner.

Myra and the ETI team are actively seeking collaborators around the world to share this model. If interested, please email us at: empowermenttherapyinstitute@gmail.com